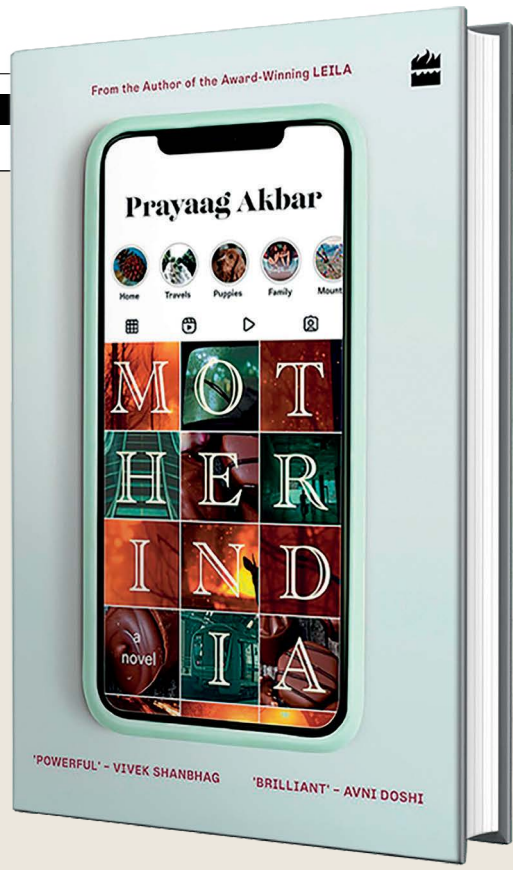


MOTHER INDIA: A Novel
by Prayaag Akbar
HARPERCOLLINS
₹499; 168 pages

new-generation couple seeking advice from Nisha on whether choosing the darkest variety of chocolate as a gift would ingratiate them to their dinner hosts.

The arrival of a Mrs Jain, the owner of the franchise, with her assistant to check on Nisha's progress after Siddharth has been promoted leads to a delicate frisson. Here two opposing streams of super-wealthy aspiration collide and jostle for space, Bollywood wives' style, in a chocolate shop.

It's obvious that no one writes novels anymore except as capsules for streaming online. Mrs Jain signals a certain Mumbaiyya class affiliation. Alas, Nisha too falls for these class differences, for which we may read caste. She finds herself telling her lowly co-worker Deven to buy himself a deodorant. Naturally, she suggests a can of Axe. Here is how it's reported: *"He was deeply dark, maybe the darkest man she'd seen, with hairy hands and neck. It seemed natural to her that he would sweat a lot, which enhanced her sense of pity."* (p. 134).

This ambiguity is what makes Akbar's work intriguing if not disturbing. His insistence on ascribing differences of birth to persons based on their community and caste, the keen sense of olfactory discrimination, not to mention those based on skin colour and texture, tend to border on the right-wing ideology that he professes to attack. Yet, let it be said that even the cover title has each letter framed against a specific political act of violence perpetrated against the people of the country. If it was the lack of water that was foregrounded in *Leila*, here it is fire.

Just as the little girl Leila disappears in the melee of a brutish regime of unbridled power, always just beyond the grasp of her birth mother, Mother India mutates in different forms with a little help from AI (artificial intelligence). Will she now appear wielding a tablet or box of chocolate in one hand and, in the other, a can of Axe deodorant to detoxify the Indian air? ■

–Geeta Doctor

across the board: Kanailal the revolutionary and his married lover Ishwari feature in some of the most explosive pages set in the past. Whereas Ayesha and Pixie—the maid's daughter and the little lady of the house, joined at the hip—keep the action every bit as compelling in the 'present' (the 2000s).

Sen's style here bears little resemblance to the Wodehouse-lite register of *Crème Brûlée*. Which isn't to say that the book isn't darkly funny when it wants to be. It's just uncommon to come across stylistic diversity like this, and that too well-executed for the majority of its 300-odd pages. Like this passage about a young girl resorting to unconventional tactics while negotiating a filthy school toilet: "Aradhana told the vice principal that it was just too gross to sit down on the toilet seat towards the end of a school day, which was entirely true, and it was the bathroom attendant who was told off for not cleaning often enough. The incident left Aradhana shaken; she took to sitting down again, as Nandini Pishi had taught her, which was entirely a good thing, for it was futile trying to do things exactly as her father did; he wasn't going to love her anyway."

Sen's style here bears little resemblance to the Wodehouse-lite register of Crème Brûlée

This passage is a microcosm of Sen's technique and within it lie several key elements to its success: shame, familial secrets, class issues, daughters over-compensating for their emotionally distant parents.

Nine out of 10 Indian novels these days read like they could easily have been 50-60 pages shorter—this is in part because of falling editorial standards. The *Lady on the Horse* is an exception. In fact, this is my (minor) complaint with the book: it could easily have been 50-60 pages longer, especially when it's bang in the middle of epoch-marking events such as Direct Action Day, 1946, or the dawn of the Naxalbari movement. For the most part, though, the book is an intergenerational saga that refuses to be weighed down by the task of capturing a century's worth of plot across just 300-odd pages. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha